Four dams. One hard choice.

ECON 238 · Week Seven · Submission packet

Prepared proposition and fieldwork materials. Election results and personal reflection remain to be completed from real evidence. No votes, quotations or display photo have been invented.

Public proposition: https://scproom.github.io/Environemtal-Econ/snake-river-deal/

Anonymous ballot: https://scproom.github.io/Environemtal-Econ/snake-river-deal/vote.html

Submission requirements

• Print the one-page poster and display it in an acceptable public location for one week. Take a real photo.

• Keep the poll open while the poster is displayed. Recruit at least 12 different voters.

• Submit the photo, working public URL, vote counts and shares, interesting comments, and short reflection.

• Assignment deadline: October 18, 2026, before 6:59 pm. A new display starting October 14 cannot complete one week by that deadline. Record the actual dates; consult the assignment exemption procedure if needed.

The proposition

Breach Four Snake River Dams and Pay to Replace Their Benefits

11 words / maximum 12

The ballot question

Shall Congress direct the U.S. Army Corps of Engineers to breach Ice Harbor, Lower Monumental, Little Goose and Lower Granite dams on the lower Snake River by December 31, 2032, and appropriate up to $20 billion over 15 years to first secure replacement carbon-free electricity, upgrade rail and highways for grain shippers, extend irrigation intakes, and compensate affected ports and communities?

61 words / maximum 75

What’s the deal?

Trade four lower Snake River dams for a better chance of recovering wild salmon and steelhead. Federal taxpayers would fund up to $20 billion over 15 years for breaching and replacement services. Tribes, fishers and people who value living salmon populations gain; electricity customers, grain shippers, irrigators and port communities face disruption. The 2022 final benefit-replacement report describes roughly 900 average megawatts of annual generation and 3,033 megawatts of installed capacity. Those are different services: replacing annual energy does not guarantee power during a cold snap. Its $10.3–$31.3 billion replacement-and-mitigation range is a 2022-dollar, largely present-value comparison, not a current construction bid. Our $20 billion appropriation is a policy choice, not proof that every cost fits. The bargain puts replacement services before breaching; it cannot promise a particular number of returning fish.

132 words / maximum 150

The best case for YES

Salmon recovery produces benefits that electricity and shipping prices leave out: ecological resilience, recreational fishing, cultural continuity and the value people place on a species surviving. NOAA’s 2022 rebuilding report identifies breaching as part of a wider recovery strategy, alongside habitat and other changes. Existing engineering can remove earthen embankments, modify irrigation intakes and expand transport infrastructure. Existing clean-energy technologies can contribute replacement power, although the complete reliable portfolio needs verification. Federal funding could spread transition costs beyond the communities that bear them. This is a case for purchasing a public environmental benefit and addressing concentrated losses. It is not a claim that every resident wins. Tribal treaty interests also deserve consideration beyond a simple dollar tally. Keeping the dams has ongoing maintenance and ecological costs; doing nothing is a choice with consequences.

133 words / maximum 150

The best case for NO

The most serious objection is delivery risk. A $20 billion cap and a 2032 deadline may not buy replacement electricity, grid reliability, shipping, irrigation and compensation together. The final 2022 report's upper estimate already exceeds that cap and excludes some costs; inflation and permitting add uncertainty. Wind and solar output cannot be equated with dispatchable hydroelectric capacity. If replacements arrive late, either breaching slips or consumers face higher costs and possible fossil generation. Salmon still encounter other dams, predators and a changing ocean, so the ecological gain is uncertain. Meanwhile, replacement power, rail and roads consume land, materials and public money that could fund other environmental improvements. Rejecting this package need not mean rejecting salmon recovery: it can mean demanding a more credible budget, sequence and comparison with alternatives.

129 words / maximum 150

Where is the body buried?

The weak link is the promise that compensation and replacements fit inside the budget on schedule. We have no engineering procurement plan demonstrating that. Money may replace shipping equipment without replacing a port community's identity or every lost livelihood. And breaching is difficult to reverse, while salmon recovery remains uncertain. The $20 billion limit is not a guarantee that affected people are made whole. If replacements cannot be secured first, the proposed timetable fails; silently weakening that condition would change the deal people voted on.

85 words / maximum 100

Why isn't this already happening?

The benefits and costs land on different people, and no single buyer can assemble the bargain cheaply. Salmon's public benefits encourage free riding; port users and utilities have direct incentives to organize against concentrated losses. Tribes are sovereign rights holders, not simply another interest group. Congress controls the federal authorization and funding, while agencies, utilities and state permitting bodies control different implementation steps. Promised future compensation is less persuasive than an existing job or power contract. Uncertain costs create incentives to bargain for more protection, and future governments may reverse commitments. Washington Commerce reports that federal withdrawal from the 2023 agreement interrupted replacement-energy analysis in 2025; a new state analysis is being procured in 2026. These are coordination and commitment problems, not evidence that opponents dislike nature. Technical feasibility alone does not establish a welfare gain or political feasibility.

139 words / maximum 150

Evidence and source notes

Final benefit-replacement report · August 2022

Executive summary pp. 1, 9–12: 900 aMW, 3,033 MW and $10.3–$31.3 billion. Values generally in April/May 2022 dollars; present values use 50 years and 2.25%. The range is not exhaustive and omits the highest energy scenarios. This replaces the draft figure used in the earlier website.

https://governor.wa.gov/sites/default/files/2022-11/LSRD%20Benefit%20Replacement%20Final%20Report_August%202022.pdf

NOAA · Rebuilding salmon and steelhead

September 2022 scientific recommendation: a suite of actions including breaching, habitat restoration, hatchery and harvest reform. A recovery strategy, not a guaranteed fish count.

https://www.fisheries.noaa.gov/media-release/rebuilding-salmon-and-steelhead-columbia-river-basin

BPA / E3 · Power replacement study

2022 scenario analysis of replacement resources and costs. Distinguish energy, firm capacity and grid services; assumptions about future technologies materially affect results.

https://www.bpa.gov/-/media/Aep/power/hydropower-data-studies/e3-bpa-lower-snake-river-dams-power-replacement-study.pdf

Washington Commerce · Replacement study status

Accessed October 14, 2026: describes the 2025 interruption and 2026 procurement. Replacement analysis is still an implementation issue, not a completed construction plan.

https://www.commerce.wa.gov/energy-policy/lower-snake-river-dam-study/

U.S. Army Corps · Lower Snake River dams

Owner/operator account of the four multipurpose dams and their navigation, hydropower and other functions. Whole Columbia–Snake shipping totals should not be mislabeled as lower-Snake-only cargo.

https://www.nww.usace.army.mil/missions/lower-snake-river-dams/

Part 4: Election results

Complete after collecting real responses. Use report.html to calculate percentages and download a text report.

Choice	Count	Share
YES	[actual count]	[actual %]
NO	[actual count]	[actual %]
YES, IF	[actual count]	[actual %]
TOTAL	[actual count]	100%

Display location and dates: [actual details]

Photo filename: [attach your photo]

Recruitment method: [how you invited different people]

Most revealing condition (verbatim): [actual response]

Strongest criticism (verbatim): [actual response]

Unexpected objection (verbatim): [actual response]

Interpretation: This is an anonymous convenience sample, not representative public opinion. YES, IF must remain separate from unconditional YES. Submission count alone does not establish distinct voters.

Part 5: Short X-style reflection

1/ I asked [N] people whether to breach four Snake River dams with up to $20B for replacements. The bargain puts salmon recovery against clean power, shipping and public spending.

2/ [Y]% said YES, [N]% NO and [C]% YES, IF. A revealing condition was: “[short actual quote]”.

3/ That response suggests [evidence-supported lesson about preferences]. I would revise [specific term] because [reason grounded in the comments].

4/ This small convenience sample cannot speak for the public. What it changed in my thinking was [your actual reflection].

Replace every bracketed field after fieldwork. Keep each finished post within 280 characters. Do not assert a lesson before observing responses.